

The Complete Financial Guide for Young Couples

month he was late with the mortgage payment and, consequently, had accumulated several months of late charges, which he refused to pay. The mortgage company had decided to take a hard stand and started foreclosure proceedings.

We scheduled an impromptu counseling session later that day. Steve and Becky were the classic opposite-personalities couple. She was a perfectionist who followed rules to the letter. He was so creative and footloose that he sometimes forgot where he put his paycheck. Because of her personality, Becky tended to see everything in black and white. To her, a foreclosure notice meant she was going to be evicted. Steve, on the other hand, simply occupied his thoughts elsewhere. His plan was to mail in the late charges at the last possible moment. It seemed perfectly justifiable to him. He was making the mortgage company "sweat," he said. In truth, he was violating his promise to pay—on time—and creating unnecessary stress for his wife.

As I got to know them better in later counseling sessions, I learned that Steve also cheated on his expense account and rarely, if ever, declared all of his income to the IRS. Steve had a spiritual flaw that was reflected in his finances.

Christ said that if a person is not faithful in the smallest of things (money), he will not be faithful in greater things: "He who is faithful in a very little thing is faithful also in much; and he who is unrighteous in a very little thing is unrighteous also in much. If therefore you have not been faithful in the use of unrighteous mammon, who will entrust the true riches to you?" (Luke 16:10-11) Jesus repeated that principle several times (verses 12-13) just to be certain that we couldn't misunderstand or misinterpret it. The way we handle our money is nothing more than the outward expression of what's going on spiritually inside.

Money can be either the best area of communication in your marriage, or it can be the worst. It's rarely neutral. If you learn to communicate properly, it can be an excellent means for understanding the assets and liabilities of one another. Remember that *different* does not mean "inferior." Each per-